



Security Watch

OS defences

The Problem



Marketing-Communications firm AvanteGarde evaluated the performance of several computer systems using the default security settings. The intention was to figure out a machine's susceptibility to being hacked over the Internet. The computers were equipped with Microsoft Windows XP SP1, XP SP1 with a third-party firewall, XP SP2, OS X 10.3.5, and Linspire's Linux.

Damages

XP SP 1 offered the lowest defence; XP SP1 with the firewall and XP SP2 fared slightly better, while OS X survived, as most attacks were Windows- oriented. Linspire's Linux was the most secure. DCOM and LSASS vulnerabilities in Windows made the attacks easier. Machines with low protection held out for 30 seconds to four minutes before losing to the hacker bots.

Precautions

Keep anti-virus software and anti-spyware installed on your system. Update XP to SP2 and always keep your anti-virus tool updated. Use third-party firewalls and regularly scan your hard disk with programs such as Ad-Aware. Make sure that your passwords are safe. Fire up the *Digit* DVD and check out the *Security* sub-section under *Digital Tools* to help protect your computer.

the Philippines, is considering moving all of its voice work there and just concentrating on data in India, even though the costs of employing an agent in the Philippines are 40 per cent higher than in India. Although India has the English language advantage at the moment, that could well change with time, and the Chinese are rapidly sprucing up spoken English capabilities in their country. The Chinese infrastructure is also better than India's."

So the moral of the story is that infrastructure is key—whether you are building a software product or a high tech city. Is the Government listening?

DESKTOP SEARCH

In The Purple Corner, It's Yahoo!

Yahoo! Inc. intends to debut a beta version of its free desktop search tool this month to compete with Google and MSN. Licensed from X1 Technologies, Yahoo's tool searches hard disks plus the Web, and is believed to be quicker at indexing and retrieval compared to Windows' search.

Unlike Google's Desktop Search tool, Yahoo's will not operate within a browser aiming to facilitate rapid browsing of search results. Incorporating navigation for

a broad range of its online services such as free e-mail, instant messenger archives and address books are the next steps Yahoo! plans to undertake.

Yahoo! claims its product can sift through over 225 different types of data. The company has no plans to place ads in its beta version, but Web searches via the tool will generate sponsored advertisements.

The drawback is that the tool does not index browser histories as yet, and is difficult to port to Mac and Linux systems.

GET REAL

Windows XP Counterfeit Project

Microsoft UK launched the Windows XP Counterfeit Project in December, as a response to the high-quality counterfeit versions of XP that were being detected. The scheme involved submitting the software to Microsoft for analysis if there was doubt about its authenticity.

The testing of the products involved filling out a witness statement, a sequence of computer checks, and information gathering. Counterfeit copies were replaced by legal XP software.

The plan enabled Microsoft to garner intelligence regarding illegal software traders and take disci-

HOT

Desktop Search



Everyone is making a tool for desktop search—

Microsoft has launched a Beta tool; Ask Jeeves would have launched theirs by the time you read this; Yahoo! will unveil one this month

WinFS

Microsoft's next-generation filesystem which was meant to make searching for files and multimedia on your computer or a network simpler and faster has been pushed back to 2007

NOT



plinary action against software pirates.

Alex Hilton, licence compliance manager at Microsoft said, "This is a great opportunity for users to confirm the authenticity of Windows XP software whilst helping gather vital information about the thriving illegal trade."

The technology and commerce industry in UK also welcomed the project. "It is important that users ensure they are legally licensed to avoid the risks of purchasing and using counterfeit products," said David Frost, the director-general at the British Chamber of Commerce.

Depending on the success of the UK project, Microsoft will consider establishing similar schemes in other countries with similar problems.



One Silly Question If your monitor went blank suddenly, what would you do?



I'll get another monitor and plug it in. If this doesn't work... chak de phatte!!
Yugbodh Singh, Mumbai



I won't be able to see anything... how can I see or save anything!!!
Pritam Ferrow, Mumbai



I'll break it so it never "blanks out" again. Na rahega baans, na bajegi bansuri!
Jaydeep Rawal, Mumbai



Wait till someone else does something... then blame him
Dilip Jha, UP



Oh, I would thank God for relieving me from the work pressure!
Chaitali Talgeri, Karnataka